A Quick French Polishing Technique

TEXT AND PHOTOS BY ANGELA AND SEAN CLARKE



Traditionally, French polishing is done completely by hand and can be somewhat labor intensive. Although we enjoy those age-old techniques and use them on pieces constructed prior to 1900, we also use French polishing techniques in conjunction with a spray gun when working on post-1900 furniture. The spray gun allows for a quick-build shellac finish that offers the same depth and clarity as a hand-rubbed surface. In addition, in conventional French polishing the shellac finish is built up with the use of oil, and the oil must then be completely removed by a process called "spiriting or stiffing off." When the shellac is sprayed, the oil becomes unnecessary, and so does the sometimes tricky spiriting-off process.

This technique works equally well on older and modern pieces, and we recently used it on an Edwardian dressing table, constructed in mahogany with satinwood banding. The existing finish was in pretty poor condition, with uneven sun-bleached areas (**1**). The first order of business was to strip all surfaces. Once the existing finish was gone, we evaluated the bare wood and determined that a thorough sanding would be necessary to remove those blotchy bleached areas. We sanded the top, sides, and drawers with an orbital sander and 320-grit paper (**2**).

Next, we wiped down all surfaces with denatured alcohol to check for color (**3**). We were looking for a consistency in both color and depth. In this case, the color was uniform, but if it hadn't been,







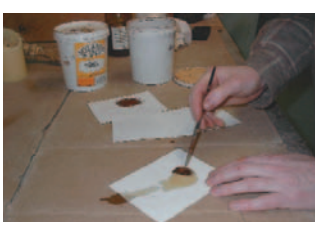


we would have stained it using a water-based aniline dye where necessary to balance the color.

Since the piece required no color work, we moved on to sealing all surfaces. We did this by spraying a "2 lb. cut" of button shellac over all surfaces (**4**). The cut refers to the ratio of shellac, which comes in a dry flake form, to its solvent (denatured alcohol). A "1 lb. cut" refers to one pound of shellac flakes mixed in a gallon of denatured alcohol. A "2 lb. cut" would be two pounds of shellac mixed in a gallon of denatured alcohol. Generally, we mix in much smaller amounts, and reduce the proportion accordingly. We like J.E. Moser's shellacs, which are available from Woodworker's Supply, because they're readily available and are a well-refined flake. We went with button shellac here because it tends to slightly deepen the color, adding a nice warm tint. After spraying one coat of the shellac, we let the piece dry overnight.

The next day, we began by lightly sanding all surfaces by hand using 320-grit paper. We concentrated on gently de-nibbing any imperfections, being careful not to sand through the sealer coat. We were now ready to begin building the finish.

We started by forming a rubber (**see sidebar below**), which is the soft pad applicator used to apply the shellac. It consists of a center core of cotton wadding that holds the shellac, with an outer sheet

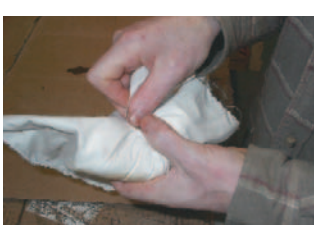


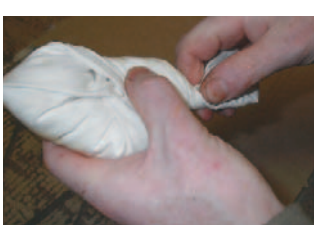














MAKING A RUBBER

First, I cut a piece of cotton (I use a good quality bed sheet) into a square about 6" x 6". This will form the outer part of the rubber, and is sometimes called a "linen." Next, I cut a piece of cotton wadding about 6" square, and fold it over several times. I moisten the wadding with denatured alcohol for absorbency, then add about 1 oz. of shellac to one surface of the wadding. I place the charged side of the wadding face down onto the center of the linen, then fold each corner of the linen into the center. I fold around one corner of the wadding, forming a point on the top of the rubber. (This point helps the rubber access corners and crevices when working.) I twist all of the linen corners together to form a "handle" for the rubber, and make sure that the flat surface on the opposite side of the rubber is completely smooth. I tap the flat surface of the rubber on the palm of my hand several times, so that the shellac in the wadding penetrates the linen. The rubber is charged and ready to go.

Note: This is only one way to create a rubber. Experiment to find what works best for you.













of cotton, sometimes called the "linen," wrapped around it. In this case, we "charged the rubber" (basically, the process of wetting the inner wadding with shellac) with super blonde shellac (**5**).

At this stage, we were going to "float a rubber" over all surfaces, which involves using the rubber to apply shellac to a surface in straight strokes, with the grain (**6**). The rubber lightly touches the surface, and sweeps back and forth, slightly overlapping the prior stroke and evenly depositing a thin skin of shellac. We find that we are better off using a pale shellac when floating a rubber to avoid the streaky color lines that seem to form when using a darker shellac. Our intent was to lay a thin skin of shellac which would pull up the sheen from where we had previously sanded, allowing us to further judge the overall color of the piece, and to spot any imperfections that would require touch-up work.

We let the shellac dry for about one hour, then took care of a few touch-ups with a mixture of shellac and dry pigment. We use Myland's pigments, available at Davis International [**1-888-369-5263**]. We have found that these pigments are available in large quantities at a reasonable price. After the touch-ups dried for another hour, we floated a rubber charged with super blonde shellac over all surfaces, which served to seal in the touch-ups. Again, the shellac needed about an hour of drying time.

At this point in French polishing, it's generally necessary to fill the grain in some manner so that the shellac layers go on smoothly, creating that clear lustrous finish that exemplifies a French polished surface. In addition, because we were working on an older piece, we wanted to replace some of the character that had been removed when it was sanded. When we need to add back some of the shading and patina that is part of the beautiful aged look of period furniture, we often use a glaze to achieve that effect. So, to accomplish both of these in one step, we decided to combine the grain filler and glaze. We mixed the following:

2 tablespoons burnt umber pigment
1 tablespoon black pigment
3 tablespoons pumice
2 oz. gold size
4 oz. mineral spirits

In this recipe, the pumice serves to fill the grain, the pigment adds color and enhances the grain, and the gold size acts as a binder so that the pigment adheres to surface. Gold size is a slow-drying varnish used in gilding**. We use the Rolco brand, which we get from Easy Leaf Products [(800) 569-5323]. It is often available in local art supply stores.**

Adding the mineral spirits reduces the viscosity of the mixture, making it more workable. We brushed this mixture over all surfaces (**7**), and then wiped off any excess with a clean cotton cloth. We left the piece to dry overnight (**8**).

We began the following day by taping off the satinwood stringing around the


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table's mirror frame. We then used 0000 steel wool to lightly remove the glaze from the stringing (**9**), and also used the steel wool to remove the glaze from all of the satinwood banding (**10**). We wanted to enhance the contrast between the satinwood and the mahogany, and removing the glaze from the lighter satinwood would help to achieve that aim. We then used the steel wool to remove some of the glaze on the rest of the piece, removing more from the center of the top (**11**) and the drawers, which creates a rubbed shaded effect that is typical of normal patterns of wear on older furniture.

Next, we sprayed one last coat of a 2 lb. cut of super blonde shellac over all surfaces (**12**). This coat acted as a sealer for the glaze, and also further built the shellac finish. The dressing table needed another night of drying time at that point.

Sprayed shellac is not as flat as is required for the final look we wanted, so on the last day of this project we started by flatting all surfaces with 400-grit paper (**13**). The flatting down creates a very even surface, but also tends to dull the finish. We floated a rubber 3-4 times over the entire piece in order to pull the sheen back up and fill any noticeable abrasions from the flatting (**14**).

We evaluated the look of the finish. Had we wanted to create a high gloss reflective surface, we would have used a polishing compound at this point to bring the sheen up even further. However, we generally find that French polishing produces a shinier surface than we prefer for the finished look of period furniture. So instead, we used 0000 steel wool to carefully dull the finish (**15**), then finished by waxing the entire piece with Kiwi Bois paste wax (**16**). This wax is without a doubt our favorite on the market in terms of workability and ease of buffing out. We get it from Hummer Capital [(**800**) **552-0052**].

We think the dressing table ended up with a French polished look that required about half the labor of a completely hand-applied finish.

Sean Clarke apprenticed with a finishing firm in London at the age of 15 while simultaneously attending the London College of Furniture. He and his wife Angela now operate Clarke Company in Valencia, California.